Heavenly Adora

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/45227077.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), (One-sided) Catra/Scorpia (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra)

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Aida AU, Opera AU, inspired by an opera, Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Catra brings Adora back in the Horde, War, Mutual Pining, Suicidal Thoughts, Angst with a Happy Ending

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Heavenly Adora

by xian70

Summary

If only I were that warrior! If only my dream would come true!... An army of brave men and women, led by me... and then the victory and the applause of the entire Fright Zone! And I will return to you, my sweet Adora, covered in glory. I'll tell you: did you see? I have finally triumphed. I proved myself worthy. And... I did it for you!

or: A Catradora reimagining of Giuseppe Verdi's opera *Aida*.

Notes

CW: mentions of death and suicidal thoughts (but none actually shown).

Yes, it's inspired by an opera. And yes, it's very melodramatic. Then again, in Italian *melodramma* is just another term for opera.
There will be four chapters, one for each of the four acts of the original libretto.

See the end of the work for more notes

Act 1

Chapter Summary

A dream fulfilled. A war anthem.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Yes," says Shadow Weaver, her annoyed voice echoing off the metallic walls of the Black Garnet chamber. "There are rumors that the Bright Moon Rebellion is daring to challenge us again and is planning a major attack on the Fright Zone through the Whispering Woods. One of our spies should be returning soon to confirm the news."

"What does Lord Hordak say?" replies Catra, standing at the door, ignoring the disgust she knows is on the witch's face, hidden behind her mask. "Does he intend to respond for once, or will he continue to remain locked in his laboratory?"

"Strangely enough, he's determined to seize the opportunity. The rebels do not know that we are aware of their plans. In fact, Lord Hordak has already chosen the Force Captain who will lead our army into battle, and he will soon announce their name."

It would be the ideal opportunity to show my worth, Catra thinks.

Shadow Weaver stares at the catgirl intently, as if she can read her mind. Then she adds: "Do not delude yourself. This is a task that requires all the skills of a strong and courageous warrior, not of an insolent and worthless child like you. But I'm sure our Lord has made the right choice. Now leave me alone. I must use my magic to make a final reconnaissance and then report to Hordak."

With her tail down, Catra leaves the room, lost in her own thoughts. Once in the corridor, her mind immediately returns to her wish.

If only I were that warrior! If only my dream would come true!... An army of brave men and women, led by me... and then the victory and the applause of the entire Fright Zone!

In a moment, however, her thoughts shift to the prisoner she captured on her most recent mission. The traitor who had defected from the Horde a few weeks earlier, but whom Catra was able to recapture and bring back at the first opportunity, as she had been ordered to do.

If I am chosen to lead our army, I will be able to return to you, my sweet Adora, covered in glory. And then I'll tell you: did you see? I have finally triumphed. I proved myself worthy. And... I did it for you!

No one is aware that Adora is actually She-Ra, the Princess of Power, who caused so much trouble for the Horde when she suddenly began appearing on the battlefield. Catra captured her before anyone else could discover her secret. This is a good thing, the catgirl thinks; if anyone suspected Adora of being She-Ra, she would be exiled to Beast Island, or worse. Instead, though stripped of any military rank, even that of a common soldier, she is allowed to remain in the Fright Zone, albeit as the lowliest of the servants, almost a slave, under constant guard. And of course she no longer has access to the magic sword, which Catra made sure to take away from her and hide in a secret place known only to the catgirl herself.

And yet... Catra loves her. Not that she ever told her, mind you. In fact, the dummy doesn't even suspect it.

Heavenly Adora, Catra thinks, the image of the blonde girl fixed in her mind. *Divine form, mystical garland of light and flowers! You are the queen of my thoughts, the secret love of my life. How I would like to give you back your freedom, and to make you breathe the sweet breezes under the blue sky... Right now, I can't. But as I gain more and more power, I will be able to put a wedding crown on your beautiful hair and to place you on a royal throne, beside me, near the sun!*

Catra's dreams of love and glory are interrupted by the arrival of Scorpia, fellow Force Captain and resident princess of the Fright Zone. Catra barely knows her, having only been on a mission with her once. But since that day, the scorpion girl won't leave her alone for a moment and follows her everywhere. Catra finds this extremely annoying and doesn't understand why she doesn't respect her personal space.

"What unusual happiness shines on your face, Wildcat!" says Scorpia. "And what noble pride flashes in your eyes! Oh, how enviable would be the person who could inspire such a light of joy in you!"

Catra ignores the nickname and blushes slightly. "My heart was just basking in an adventurous dream," she replies. "Today Lord Hordak will announce the name of the Force Captain who will lead the Horde army in the final battle against the Rebellion. Ah! If I were chosen for such an honor..."

"Is that all? And wasn't there another dream that spoke to your heart? A kinder, sweeter one? Have you no other desires... or hopes?"

"I..." Catra stammers. And then she thinks to herself: *Why does she ask me this? Maybe... she has discovered the secret love which burns in my heart! Did she read Adora's name in my mind?*

Scorpia actually has a hunch. She can't help but notice how Catra's expression changes every time she looks at the prisoner. And of course, just at that moment, Adora appears around the corner and timidly approaches the two Force Captains with her eyes downcast. Her cheeks are lined, as if she'd just cried.

Catra sees her and staggers. Scorpia notices, as if to confirm her doubts. The scorpion princess immediately turns to the newcomer.

"Come closer, dear Adora, don't be afraid," Scorpia says. "You know that you are not a prisoner to me, but almost a sister. I haven't forgotten that you were one of us, trained right here in

the Fright Zone. Is something wrong? Are you sad? Tell us the cause of your pain."

"Um... it's nothing, really!" the blonde answers. "I'm just worried about the war. I understand that other battles are near, and I fear for the fate of my friends."

"Is that your only concern?" asks an inquiring Scorpia, her gaze shifting from Adora to Catra again and again. "Is there really nothing else that troubles you?"

That's it. Scorpia certainly suspects something, Catra thinks. *I can see it in her face. But if she finds out about Adora's secret, or even worse, about my feelings for her, it will be the end for both of us.*

Adora, too, feeling watched, trembles. She can't reveal that she's worried about one person in particular, the one who captured her and brought her back here. The one who was once her friend and now hates her. The one who, she's sure, will soon plunge headlong back into battle and danger.

Suddenly, loud sirens sound in the corridor, announcing a general assembly. Lord Hordak is calling all troops to the throne room. "The time has come for the big reveal!", Catra says. And then she thinks: *Let's hope it goes well.*

Catra and Scorpia walk quickly down the corridor. After a moment's hesitation, Adora decides to follow them, keeping her distance. She wants to know what's going on.

They enter the great hall where all the soldiers and captains are already lined up in formation. There are also many officials and guards, and even a few cadets. Lord Hordak is standing in front of his throne, with Shadow Weaver, the sorceress, at his side. Once everyone is in place, the Horde leader begins to speak in a deep voice.

"My trusted warriors, I have called you here for a very important reason. One of our spies has just arrived from the Whispering

Woods with grave news. But hear it for yourselves. Let the messenger come forward!”

In response to Hordak’s words, an armored soldier steps to the center of the hall and begins to speak.

“The wicked princesses are on a war footing. They have already attacked numerous settlements that we had conquered in recent years and that were essential to our livelihood. They have ravaged the fields and burned our crops. And now, emboldened and encouraged by these easy victories, they are determined to march directly against the Fright Zone.”

“They will pay for their audacity!” shouts Shadow Weaver.

“The Rebellion is led by a fierce and relentless warrior: Princess Glimmer,” the messenger adds.

That sparkly girl!, Catra thinks.

Glimmer!, Adora frowns.

“My Lord,” Shadow Weaver says to Hordak, “our troops are already at arms. At your command, they are ready to fall upon the barbarian invaders and spread war and death upon them.”

“Yes,” says Lord Hordak. “Let war and death be our battle cry!”

“War!” shouts Catra, raising her fist.

“War! War! Raging, merciless war!” all the soldiers echo.

At a nod from Hordak, the voices subside. Then the Horde leader lowers his arm and says, “As for the commander who will lead our invincible legions, I have made my decision. Step forward, Force Captain Catra!”

“Catra!” shouts everyone present, not without astonishment. The only one who remains silent is Shadow Weaver, her expression inaccessible behind her mask.

Ah!, Catra rejoices internally as a grin spreads across her face. *Thank the gods! My wish has come true!*

"Wildcat!" Scorpia exclaims with a smile, happy for her friend.

That can't be!, Adora thinks.

"Catra!" all the soldiers and captains shout. "Catra! Catra! Catra!"

"Force Captain Catra!" Lord Hordak addresses her. "Prepare for your task and lead us to victory!" And then, speaking to the entire army, "Proud warriors of the Horde. Be worthy of the destiny for which you have trained all your lives. From each of your souls, let a cry of war and death herald our advance!"

"War and death! War and death!" the soldiers cry in unison.

"But be careful," Shadow Weaver interjects. "The enemy is dangerous. Use every resource at your disposal. The tide of this war is about to turn; this will be the final battle." And then she adds: "Soldiers! Captains! Your own bodies shall be a barrier against the enemy. War and death to the princesses!"

"War and death! War and death!"

War? D-death? Adora thinks. *It can't be! This isn't happening! And here I am, completely helpless. Glimmer will fight... Catra will fight...! Catra! D-death? Oh gods, no!*

All caught up in the fervor, Catra smiles at the soldiers around her or who come to congratulate her. She feels her whole soul invested by the thrill of glory. Then she turns to her companions and urges them on: "Come, victory awaits us. War and death to the princesses!"

"War! War! Death! Death to the princesses!" the soldiers continue to shout.

Scorpia smiles at her, too: "Boss, I'll be at your side. And I'll help you hold up our glorious banner. Let's walk this path of glory

together!”

“Force Captain Catra!” Lord Hordak shouts solemnly. “Go and return victorious!”

“Return victorious!” all the soldiers shout.

“Return victorious!” Scorpia joins them.

“Return victorious!” shouts Adora as well. She immediately becomes aware of her words and kneels down on the ground near the wall. Hardly anyone notices her as the troops begin to leave.

Soon the hall empties and Adora is left alone, still on the floor. She is trembling. And her mind goes back to the words she just said.

Return victorious!, she thinks to herself. *D-did I really say that? Did I... shout it? Do I really want Catra to defeat the Rebellion and the princesses? To be victorious over Glimmer? To kill her...? Glimmer, who probably decided to take up arms and attack the Fright Zone just to free me, as well as to end the threat of the Evil Horde once and for all?*

Her head spins. Something burning inside prevents her from getting up. *If I were free, if I had my sword, I could do something*, she thinks. *But I’m helpless. And yet... I said that. Yes, I wished Catra to return victorious. I wished her success, to be welcomed in triumph by Hordak and the Horde. To come back stained with the blood of the princesses. To bring death upon them, or at best, to bring them back captive, in chains.*

Slowly, Adora gets up, leaning her hand against the cold wall. The whirlwind of emotions inside her does not seem to cease, on the contrary it becomes more and more swirling. *Ah, if only I could escape and rejoin the Rebellion, fight again alongside Glimmer, Bow and the other princesses! As She-Ra, I could surely turn the tide of battle in our favor... I could help slay the enemy forces. Oh my God, no! What am I thinking? S-slay... Catra? It’s the final battle, no one will retreat... War and death, they said! Could I*

ever kill Catra? The one I... I love? And to think I never told her... Can I forget this burning love, the only thing that makes me happy even here, where I'm a prisoner? Can I cause her death, or even invoke it? She who I love so much? Oh gods, has there ever been anyone more desperate and tormented than me?

As she leaves the large and now empty hall, Adora is wracked with guilt. Her conflicting emotions merge and overlap. Whose victory should she wish for? And whose defeat, or possibly death? Tears spill down her cheeks and dark thoughts enter her mind. *Good heavens, have mercy on my suffering. There is no hope in my pain. Oh, love, fatal and terrible love... break my heart, let me die!*

"Did you hear that, witch?" Catra says to Shadow Weaver, a defiant tone in her voice. "Hordak chose me. He saw in me what you could never see. And I will not disappoint him."

"That remains to be seen," the sorceress replies scornfully. "But unfortunately, you're right. Lord Hordak has indeed chosen you. So you must not fail this time. My own position will also depend on it."

"Don't worry, I won't fail," Catra smiles. "I assure you!"

"I really hope so," says Shadow Weaver. "Remember, you are entrusted with the fate of the entire Horde. Ah, if Adora hadn't fallen from grace, she would have been the chosen one for sure... I had such high hopes for that girl... But let's forget that. Now come closer. I will cast a spell on your battle staff to make it invincible. I never thought I'd have to waste such powerful magic on a pathetic and incompetent creature like you, but I have no choice."

Silently, Catra approaches the Black Garnet and hands her staff to the woman. The catgirl doesn’t like magic and keeps as far away from it as she can, but she knows that any help she can get in this task is more than welcome.

Catra shudders as purple smoke, tinged with electrical discharges, rises from the witch’s cauldron and slowly engulfs her. Shadow Weaver, holding the staff in her hand, speaks in a low voice: “Force Captain! In your hand, this weapon, tempered by magic, will become terror, lightning, and death to our enemies!”

The smoke slowly dissipates. The staff now seems more... powerful, almost intimidating. Shadow Weaver hands it back to her, and Catra takes it. She immediately senses its strength. Is this what Adora felt when she wielded that stupid magic sword of hers?

“You can go now,” Shadow Weaver tells her. “Do your best. Protect the Fright Zone and defeat the invaders. But do not think that the outcome of the battle depends on you alone. Remember that fate is the only guide and arbiter of any human war!”

Catra does not know what to say. As the sorceress turns away from her, the catgirl clenches the staff in her fist and leaves the room. The moment of truth approaches.

Chapter End Notes

> I resisted the urge to change the names of the characters (Aidora, Catramès...) to make them more similar to those of the original opera. No need to thank me.

Act 2

Chapter Summary

A secret revealed. A triumphal march.

Scorpia is back in her private quarters. She has just returned from the battlefield: the fight ended at dawn, and there was no reason for all the Force Captains to remain there. Soon the others will join her in the Fright Zone, along with most of the troops. Meanwhile, the scorpion princess wanted to be among the first to bring the news of the war's outcome to those who had remained waiting. As she entered the Fright Zone, bearing the marks of the terrible battle on her body, crowds of young cadets stood by, watching her with curiosity and admiration.

Sitting on the bed in her room, Scorpia removes her armor and sighs. The silence is broken by a knock at the door. "Come in," Scorpia says. She is not surprised to see it's Adora.

She came here to find out how the battle ended, the Force Captain thinks to herself. *Her face is pale... Looking at her, my fearful suspicions awaken again. Perhaps it's time to set the record straight once and for all and get to the bottom of this deadly mystery.*

"Come, Adora, don't be afraid," she tells her. "I don't want to keep you hanging. We won the battle. The Horde has finally defeated the Princess Alliance. The tide of war has turned against your Rebellion."

The blonde shudders.

"Poor Adora!" Scorpia continues. "I know how you feel. The defeat of your friends weighs on your heart. I share your grief: after all, as I already said, I'm your friend too. And don't worry: nothing will change, you can stay here in the Fright Zone, you will have everything you want. You shall be happy!"

“How can I be happy?” replies Adora. “How can I when I know nothing about the fate of my friends? I am worried! Tell me, are they still alive? What happened to Glimmer and the other princesses?”

“I can’t tell you. I only know that our troops have taken many prisoners and will soon bring them here... probably to be executed. But there are also many who died in the field. The battle was extremely bloody. There is no complete list of casualties yet.”

“Oh gods!” Adora exclaims.

“I understand your pain. But rest assured, there are limits to earthly grief. Time will heal all wounds and soothe the anguish of your heart. And perhaps something even more powerful than time will do it... Love!”

Love!, Adora thinks. *Love is both joy and torture for me! It’s like a sweet rapture, a cruel anxiety! Oh Catra, when I think of you... You’re my life, your smile opens the heavens to me...*

Ah, this pallor..., Scorpia thinks, staring at Adora with intensity. *This uneasiness undoubtedly betrays a secret fever of love. I’m almost afraid to question her, I feel like I share her heart’s fear.*

“So,” the scorpion princess resumes, “what other anguish disturbs you, Adora? Tell me your secrets, confide in me. Maybe... you’re not just worried about the fate of the princesses? Maybe you fear for someone who fought on the Horde’s side too? Someone who arouses a sweet pain in your heart?”

“What do you mean?” Adora says, trying to hide her feelings.

It’s now or never, thinks Scorpia. *I will know the truth.*

“Don’t worry,” she tells Adora. “After all, fate was not cruel to everyone. There were many survivors. Many were lucky, unlike Catra...”

“Catra! What did you say?”

“Yes, unfortunately. My Wildcat fell in battle, slain by the princesses...”

“No! That can’t be!”, Adora cries.

“What? Are you weeping for her?” says Scorpia.

“I will never stop my weeping!”

“But she was your enemy!”

“No, she wasn’t! Oh, gods!”

“So that’s it,” says Scorpia. “It’s clear. You love her!”

“I...” says Adora.

“Don’t lie! I just need to tell you one more thing, and then I’ll have the proof. Listen carefully and look into my eyes. I have deceived you... Catra is alive!”

“She’s alive!” cries the blonde. “Oh, thank the gods!”

“And you still thought you could fool me? Yes, you love her. But... I love her too. Do you understand, Adora? I’m your rival! And most importantly, I’m a princess. Catra deserves a bride of royal rank!”

“My rival...!” Adora stammers. Angry at being deceived, the blonde lifts her head proudly and replies without thinking. “Well, so be it! I am a princess too, I am...”.

But she immediately realizes that she cannot reveal her secret. No one must know that she is She-Ra, Princess of Power, if she is to have any hope of survival. No one. Lowering again her head, she exclaims: “Ah, what am I saying? Forgive me, Scorpia, please!”

“What was that?” asks the scorpion girl, puzzled.

“Have pity on me! Yes, it’s true... I love Catra. I love her so much, with an immense and secret love. I have never revealed it to her... You are a Force Captain, respected, powerful... I’m just a slave now, and I live only for this love. Please don’t take this hope away from me!”

Scorpia feels her soul fill with jealousy. She is angrier than she has ever been in her life. “Enough! Silence your heart!” she shouts. “And realize that this love can seal your fate. You are not the master of your destiny here, I am! And I feel myself raging with hate and revenge!”

Adora shudders and falls to her knees. A few seconds pass. She is about to speak again, when shouts of triumph echo from outside. The Horde soldiers have returned! And the young cadets sing a chorus of welcome: “Onward! At the gates of the Fright Zone, let us storm with pride! We must celebrate our soldiers who brought war and death to the cruel princesses!”

“Adora, get up!” Scorpia exclaims. “Come with me. You too shall witness the return of Catra and all the celebrations of her victory. But I will be in the front row, along with the other Force Captains, to see my Wildcat receive Hordak’s praise and... my proposal of marriage. And you will remain in the background, watching from afar as she is cheered for her bravery.”

“Have mercy!” Adora complains. “What will be left for me if you take Catra? I’ve already lost everything, first my freedom and now my friends. My life is a desert now. Don’t take her away from me, too. I’d rather die! And maybe I’ll take this love that troubles you so much to my grave”.

“Don’t talk nonsense and follow me. Soon we’ll see if you’re really worthy to be my rival,” Scorpia cuts her off, opens the door of her room and stomps out at a fast pace.

Adora remains alone for a moment. *Oh gods, at least have mercy on me and my suffering. There is no hope for my sorrow!*. Then she leaves and walks slowly towards the throne room.

The great hall is buzzing with excitement. All the cadets and officials are assembled, ready to triumphantly greet the troops and the captains who covered themselves in glory by finally defeating the hated princesses. The cold metal walls are decorated for the occasion with flags and signs bearing the Horde's coat of arms. Even the throne of Hordak, at the top of the grand staircase, is adorned with a purple canopy.

Lord Hordak himself enters and sits on his throne. Standing to his right is Shadow Weaver. From the open gates, the footsteps of approaching soldiers can be heard in the distance. The cadets greet them with another chorus of welcome: "Glory to the Horde! Glory to Hordak, who leads us to rule Etheria! Let us sing a joyous hymn to the heroic warriors who have achieved victory! Glory! Glory! Glory to Hordak!"

Catra leads the way, staff in hand, followed by the other Force Captains and then the ranks of soldiers, many bearing the marks of hard combat on their bodies and armor. The Horde legions fill the great hall and line up before the throne. The music of a triumphal march rises in the air, accompanying their steps. Meanwhile, the cadet choirs continue: "Let a laurel wreath be woven in the hair of the victors! Glory to Hordak! Glory to the Horde! Glory to Catra! Let us sing a joyous hymn to the heroic warriors!"

Adora, standing behind the cadets, watches the entire ceremony with growing trepidation. Her gaze rests on Catra, admiring the expression of pride that flashes across the beautiful catgirl's face. But her heart is tense, full of fear for the fate of the princesses and the other Rebellion fighters. The triumphal march continues in a heroic and glorious crescendo.

Finally, the music stops. Lord Hordak rises from his throne and stands. He looks down and speaks directly to Catra.

"Force Captain, I salute you. You have served the Horde well. And you shall be rewarded for your bravery. Nothing shall be withheld from you this day, I swear it. Come forward and take the place to my left. From this day on, you will share the role of second-in-command with Shadow Weaver. Together, now that the threat of the evil princesses has been eliminated, we will bring order to Etheria and shape it to our liking."

"Thank you, my Lord," Catra replies. "But first, allow the prisoners to be brought before you."

Adora gasps. Through the doors, in chains and escorted by some guards, numerous defeated rebel warriors enter. She recognizes many of them, most being Bright Moon soldiers. She can read all the hardships and the tragic weight of the lost battle on their suffering faces. But none of the princesses seem to be among them. Until...

...of course! Hidden among the soldiers, dressed and disguised as one of them, is undoubtedly Glimmer! She's not wearing her usual princess attire, but a battered breastplate and a hood covering her signature pink hair. But it's her, no doubt. And she's alive!

"Oh gods!" the blonde girl exclaims, coming out of the ranks of the cadets and running towards her. "It's you! Glim..."

"Sshhh!" her friend whispers abruptly. "Don't say my name out loud!"

But it's too late. All eyes are on them now. Shadow Weaver steps forward and speaks directly to the prisoner. "And who are you?" she asks.

"I am... just a common soldier of the Rebellion," Glimmer replies, looking up at the throne, "and... Adora's friend."

Her friend?, Catra wonders.

“I fought bravely on behalf of my princess,” Glimmer continues. “But it was all in vain. We were defeated, and I narrowly escaped death myself. The condition of my armor should tell you how fiercely I tried to defend my kingdom. But alas, fate was against us. Our audacity proved to be useless...”

“And where is your commander?” asks Shadow Weaver. “What is the fate of the princess of Bright Moon?”

“I witnessed her death. Right beside me, at my feet, Princess Glimmer fell, wounded and pierced by the enemies’ blows.”

A gasp of astonishment fills the hall.

“Now we are your prisoners,” Glimmer continues, “but know this: if love of one’s kingdom is a crime, if devotion to a good cause is an offense, then we are all guilty, and we are ready to die,” Glimmer says proudly.

Then she changes her tone and addresses Hordak directly, pleading: “But you, mighty Lord of the Horde, have mercy. You have won, the Rebellion is scattered, there is no one left in Etheria to stand in your way. Now be merciful and spare our lives. An evil fate has struck us today, as it may have struck you if things had gone differently. And to you, soldiers of the Horde, I say this to all of you: I hope you’ll never have to suffer as we have suffered today.”

Then Adora herself speaks, also addressing the leader of the Horde in pleading tones: “Lord Hordak, please, I too beg mercy for them. Killing the prisoners would do no good to you. They are no longer a danger. Without a guide, without the princesses, the people of Bright Moon are harmless.”

Shadow Weaver turns to Hordak too, speaking in a scornful voice: “My Lord, do not listen to them! Close your heart to their traitorous pleas, and destroy these ferocious crews. Destiny has doomed them to die, so now let its will be done. All prisoners must be executed!”

“Have mercy, Lord Hordak!” Adora cries. “Have mercy!”

Catra remains silent, seemingly impassive, her emotions impenetrable. But her tail flicks, and her gaze is fixed on Adora. *The sorrow that speaks through her blue eyes makes her even more beautiful*, she thinks. *Every drop of tears that lines her cheeks deepens more and more the love that burns hidden in my chest.*

And Scorpia, watching the catgirl instead, reflects: *She doesn’t take her eyes off her even for a second. Not even now, in the moment of her triumph, does she think of anything but her. She cannot deceive me, I know very well what flame flashes inside her. My Wildcat loves Adora. Yes, there is no doubt. And will I have to remain alone, dejected, outcast? My heart is roaring, but what can I do? Everything is getting out of hand...*

Finally, Catra makes up her mind and turns to Hordak. “My Lord,” she says to him. “You just swore that nothing would be withheld from me on this day. Well, I hold you to your word. And I ask for life and freedom for the prisoners of Bright Moon. For all of them!”

“All of them?” interjects Shadow Weaver. “No, my Lord, no way! Death to the enemies of the Horde!”

Hordak seems to think long and hard. Finally, he raises his arm and shouts, “So be it!” to all present. “It is true that fate has turned in our favor. Killing these soldiers and the people of Bright Moon would do the Horde no good. Their land is taken. Someone will have to farm the fields, work the mines, and provide us with food and materials. And many of them will become part of our army. So it is better for us to show mercy. The war is over, now comes the time of my peaceful reign over the entire planet. Let them be free!”

“You make a mistake, my Lord. Death to them! Death!” says Shadow Weaver.

“My mind is already made up,” says Hordak. “Or dare you defy my wishes, sorceress?”

“Listen, my Lord,” says Shadow Weaver. And then, turning to Catra, she adds: “You too, Force Captain, listen for once to some wise counsel. These warriors are our enemies, and they have already proven to be brave. Their hearts are now burning with vengeance. Encouraged and emboldened by our mercy, they will run to take up arms again!”

“Haven’t you heard?” says Catra. “Princess Glimmer, their leader, is dead. Without her, they can no longer hope to fight us!”

Finally, Shadow Weaver seems to give up. She pauses, takes a long sigh, and then adds: “But at least, as a pledge of peace and security, let Adora and her... friend... remain with us.”

“So be it,” Hordak says. “Now, break ranks, Horde warriors! It is time to rest and regroup. Except for these two, all prisoners shall be released! May the Horde rule Etheria forever!”

“Yes, my Lord!” the soldiers exclaim in unison. “Glory to the Horde! Glory to Hordak! Glory to Catra! Glory! Glory!”

Hordak and Shadow Weaver leave the throne room. The guards escort the prisoners out. Once again, the great hall empties. And in the confusion, four individuals are lost in their own swirling thoughts.

I triumphed at last!, Catra thinks. *I won the war. I finally proved myself. And yet... none of that seems to matter now. Nothing seems to me as precious as Adora’s smile. It’s her heart, the only thing I really want to conquer. But will I ever be able to?*

My head is spinning, Scorpia thinks. *Everyone around me is rejoicing, they’re happy... I, on the other hand, am overwhelmed by pain. Catra loves Adora. She doesn’t love me, she never will. What am I going to do? How can I change my fate?*

The war is lost, Adora thinks. *The Rebellion is defeated. But at least... Glimmer is alive. And the people of Bright Moon were spared. Maybe there is still hope. If I can get my sword back... I could escape with Glimmer. And Catra... Catra, my love, how I wish I could open my heart to you!*

Adora, be brave!, Glimmer thinks. *Wait patiently, all is not lost. We survived, and no one here knows my identity. With my teleportation powers, we can escape whenever I want. But first I have a mission to accomplish. There is still hope of turning the tide of the war upside down. No one suspects it, but the day of our vengeance is at hand!*

Act 3

Chapter Summary

A declaration of love. A cruel betrayal.

Wiping her sweaty brow with the palm of her hand, Adora leans the mop against the barracks wall. Her shift cleaning the cadets' dormitories is almost over. It is a job that in other times could have been done by a robot, but almost all of the machinery has been relocated for the war, and much of it was destroyed in the last battle. That she, once the most brilliant of the cadets of the Horde, now has to sweep the floor and clean the barracks is almost ironic. But Adora doesn't care. Any activity that distracts her is welcome.

Since the day before, she has not been able to talk to anyone. Neither with Catra nor with Glimmer... Glimmer, who, like her, has been assigned to work in the Fright Zone. No one suspects her of being a princess, everyone thinks she is just another citizen of Bright Moon, and that is why she is not locked in a cell. *At least we have some freedom of movement*, the blonde thinks. *We can't escape, because the gates are guarded and all access to the outside is forbidden, but nothing prevents us from traveling at least with the imagination...*

Adora picks up the mop again, determined to give the floors one last pass. But she stops almost immediately, her mind wandering to the outside world.

Perhaps I'll never see Bright Moon again. The blue skies, the soft breezes, where I serenely flew with my steed... O grassy hills, o fragrant streams, I shall never see you again! O cool valleys, o blessed, peaceful haven, where I wandered happily with my friends... and where I dreamed of walking hand in hand with my love... a dream that is now vanished forever... I shall never see you again!

Just then, Glimmer herself enters the room. “Adora! Thank goodness I found you,” the princess whispers.

“Glimmer! You’re here!” the blonde says.

“Are we alone?”

“Yes, but be careful. The guards are watching us. They could come at any moment.”

“Then let’s use this opportunity. I have a lot to tell you.”

“Me too!” Adora says, taking both of her hands in her own. “But first... Oh, Glimmer! Tell me: what happened to Bow, Perfuma and the other princesses?”

“They are alive. They escaped the battle and went into hiding with part of our army. Adora, it was terrible! So many died! But all is not lost!”

“They are alive! Thank the gods!” Adora exclaims.

“What about you? Can you turn back into She-Ra? Where’s the sword?” Glimmer asks.

“Catra took it away from me. And she hid it who knows where. Glimmer, I don’t think I can get it back...”

“Does Catra have it? Then we still have hope.”

“What do you mean?” says Adora, confused.

“If Shadow Weaver or even Hordak had taken the sword, it would be almost impossible to get it back. But Catra loves you, even if she’s an annoying bitch, and maybe it’s possible to trick her...”

“W-what? What are you saying? She loves me?”

“You’re such an idiot, Adora! Of course she loves you! And we have to take advantage of that,” Glimmer says.

“I... I... But I... I...” Adora stammers, her cheeks blushing bright red. She almost feels like she can’t talk anymore.

“Listen! Thanks to my magic, I could teleport out of the Fright Zone at any moment. And take you with me. We would end up at the edge of the Whispering Woods, and from there the road to freedom would be open to us. But that time has not yet come. First, we must do something very important. It’s not just about the sword.”

“Then what is it?” asks Adora, who is slowly starting to function again.

“The troops led by Bow and our friends have taken refuge in a secret valley and are slowly trying to make their way back to Bright Moon. But the Horde armies are watching every mountain pass. They know that many soldiers have escaped the battle. And they are waiting for them. No doubt they will try to ambush them. It is imperative that someone find out where the enemy is positioned and which routes are open.”

“But who could find out that?”

“You could! That is where you come in, Adora,” Glimmer tells her.

“Me? And how?”, Adora asks.

“Exploit Catra! As I said, she loves you. And she is the commander of the Horde armies... Do you understand?...”

“What? Are you suggesting that I...”

“That you steal her trust, yes! In war and in love, everything is allowed. Even deception. Force Catra to reveal where her troops are located. Do it for the Rebellion. And so our friends will return home safely, to see again our fragrant forests, the cool valleys, and the golden towers.”

“Exploit Catra... deceive her!” says Adora. “I don’t know if I can do it... If Hordak finds out that she has revealed their secrets, she

will be considered a traitor! She will be punished, banished, or perhaps executed! No, I can't do it!"

"Adora!" Glimmer shakes her. "Don't forget that she is our enemy. Remember that the Evil Horde has destroyed our villages, our homes. They took many of our men and women. They slaughtered mothers, old men and children!"

"Ah, Glimmer! Of course I remember! I remember well the losses this war has brought us. But to add new ones... No, you are right. I cannot allow our friends to be killed. We must save them. And we will! I shall be worthy of the Alliance," Adora says. And then she thinks: *Even at the cost of my own happiness. Catra loves me back, and I will betray her.*

"Now you're talking, Adora!" says the princess. "Now hurry... Catra is coming! I'll hide behind this locker. Remember... you can do it. Nothing is impossible for a brave heart!"

Glimmer hides just in time. After a few seconds, Force Captain Catra actually enters the barracks. As soon as the catgirl sees the blonde, mop in hand, standing alone in the room, a smile appears on her face. "Hey, Adora," she says.

"Catra," Adora replies. Her swirling mind goes back to the words Glimmer just said to her. *She loves you.* Yes, she said that. But is that ever possible? Is there still any hope, then, for her most intimate and secret dream? Adora feels her legs tremble. But she tries to be strong.

"Um... how are you?" Catra asks her. Her gaze is sheepish, and her beautiful heterochromatic eyes betray her hidden emotions. *So it's really true*, Adora thinks. *She loves me. How could I not notice? I really am an idiot.*

"I'm very well, thank you!" replies Adora. "I'm getting pretty good at cleaning barracks. It looks like we'll both have good careers here in the Horde."

Catra doesn't laugh at the joke. She lowers her ears and runs a hand behind her head. "Adora, look... I'm so sorry. I'll try to talk to Lord Hordak and get you assigned to something better..."

"Don't worry, it's okay," the blonde tells her. "But thank you. I know you care about me."

"Yes, I do. I... will always care about you," Catra replies.

It's time, Adora thinks. *I have to try. Gods, how I hate myself for what I'm about to do!*

But before Adora can open her mouth, Catra speaks again.

"You know, Adora..." she says. "Even if the war is won, not all the fighting is over. Some remnants of Bright Moon's army are still lurking in the mountains, eager for fierce new battles. I have been ordered to track them down. It won't be difficult. And amid the cheers of this new triumph, I will bow before Lord Hordak and ask him the greatest of all favors. Your freedom! You will be free, Adora, to go wherever you want. Or... to live here, close to me... if you want to, of course."

Adora is speechless. Even now, as an enemy, Catra wishes her well. And wants to protect her. Oh gods, how she loves her! Oh, cursed fate!

"And you do not fear Shadow Weaver's wrath?" Adora says. "She will never allow me to be free, or for us to be happy together. Her vengeance will fall on me, on you, on everyone, like a terrible bolt of lightning."

"I will defend you! The witch doesn't scare me."

"Oh, Catra! It would be in vain. You couldn't. But... if you wish... there is another way out for us..."

"Which is?"

"To flee together!"

“What do you mean? To flee...?”

“Listen to me very carefully,” Adora tells her. “By now, you have already proven yourself... You have shown everyone that you are a worthy leader, and that Shadow Weaver was always wrong in judging you. Staying here in the Horde serves you no further purpose. Let us flee these barren and inhospitable lands! A new home may be revealed to us, and there... among virgin forests, fragrant with sweet flowers, we shall forget all our sufferings, and live in blessed joy.”

Catra turns pale. “You are asking me to flee... with you... to a foreign land?”

“Yes. Come with me, Catra. Let’s do it!”

“A-Adora!” Catra says hesitantly, stepping back.

“Don’t... don’t you want it? Did I misunderstand, then? You... you don’t love me?” says the blonde.

“W-what are you saying? I don’t love you?”

“I get it...! Then go away! Leave me forever!”

“Adora!” Catra rushes forward, grabbing her hands. “Oh, Adora! My sweet Adora! Oh yes, yes, yes, yes, I love you, I always have! Oh, gods!”

“Oh, Catra... I love you too! I love you so much!”

“Adora... Yes, let’s flee together!”. The catgirl is ecstatic. “Let us flee, far away from these walls, from this cursed Fright Zone. Here there is nothing but misery, there we will find a heaven of love. The infinite spaces will be our home, all the moons of Etheria will shine upon us with a purer, brighter light!”

“Let us go then,” Adora adds, “let us flee together from this land of pain. Cool valleys and green fields will be our home. And love will be our guide!”

Still holding hands, the two girls timidly approach each other, close the space between their lips, and exchange a soft but passionate kiss. It lasts only a few seconds, but to Adora it seems like an eternity. It's the happiest moment of her life. She distinctly hears Catra purr.

And then, as they pull apart, the blonde forces herself to speak again.

“But tell me, Catra. Which way shall we go? How can we avoid the legions of the Horde?”

“Do not worry, dummy,” Catra says, her voice full of sweetness. “The route on which our soldiers will march against the enemy will be free until tomorrow.”

“And that route is...?”

“The pass to Elberon”, Catra answers.

“The pass to Elberon!” Glimmer exclaims, stepping out from behind the locker. “That’s all I needed to know!”

“Who’s there?” the catgirl exclaims in surprise as she spots the intruder. “Who was listening to us?”

“It’s me, Princess Glimmer of Bright Moon!” she replies proudly, pulling down the hood that covered her hair to reveal herself.

“You!... Sparkles!... You...” Catra says in shock. “Ah, no! Betrayal! What did I say! No, it can’t be true...”. The catgirl glances desperately at Adora, who looks sad and guilty as she steps back to stand beside Glimmer. “It’s a nightmare... a delirium!”

“No, Catra, no!” says Adora. “Calm down. Listen to me...”

“You fooled me... tricked me!”

“No, Catra! I really love you...”

“It’s true,” Glimmer says. “Listen to her, Horde scum!”

“And I... betrayed the Horde for you!” Catra cries in anger.

“Calm down, Catra, my love...” Adora weeps, her eyes already full of tears.

“Do not call me that! You have deceived me, as always!” Catra says angrily. Her eyes are filled with burning rage instead.

“Catra!” Glimmer retorts, holding out her hand. “Don’t talk nonsense. Come on, you can escape with us. Come on!”

“Guards! Guards! Hurry! Betrayal!” Catra cries with every breath in her lungs.

“Ugh, it’s useless!” Glimmer says. And grabbing Adora by the shoulders, she teleports the blonde and herself away with her magic.

Two Horde guards, followed by Shadow Weaver herself, enter the barracks. But they find Catra alone, crying and kneeling on the floor. “What happened, Force Captain? Why did you scream?” the sorceress asks.

“Witch, you won!” Catra says, looking up at her. “I am a traitor. I confess. Do with me whatever you want.”

And then she collapses to the ground.

Act 4

Chapter Summary

A death sentence. An unexpected encounter.

I can't believe it!, Scorpia thinks, nervously pacing the corridor leading to the great throne room, its door still barred. *My Wildcat... she can't be a traitor. And yet she has confessed. And now she awaits the traitor's punishment...*

The scorpion princess stops in her tracks. She leans her forehead against the cold door of the hall. *But she's no traitor,* she thinks. *I am sure of it! And yet... yet she has revealed to the enemy a secret plan of warfare. She has let two prisoners escape... including Princess Glimmer, the Horde's most deadly foe. This is treason. And she deserves to die!*

A jolt, and Scorpia resumes her pace back and forth in the hallway. *Oh! What am I thinking? This can't be! I love her! I want to be loyal to Catra, not to the Horde. What does it matter if she can never love me? I want to save her anyway. But how? She confessed... Yet I must try!*

With a whoosh, the door to the great hall finally opens. Scorpia rushes in and is one of the first to enter. Behind her, the other Force Captains and all the Horde officials slowly follow. The atmosphere is somber and gloomy, a far cry from the joyous celebrations of a few days before. Once again, Lord Hordak sits on his throne, his eyes narrowed and his face brooding, his forehead resting on his fist. And once again, Shadow Weaver stands to his right, her expression impenetrable behind the mask that covers her visage.

Catra, on the other hand, is at the bottom of the staircase. In chains. On her knees. Resigned, waiting to be judged.

“Wildcat!” Scorpia shouts, trying to reach her with her words. “You can still clear yourself of this terrible accusation! Defend yourself! Say that they deceived you, that they did it to find out the secret. Say that you are loyal!”

“Shut up, Big Gal,” says Catra, turning for a moment to her fellow captain. “Hordak and the witch will never hear a word of my excuses. My careless words have indeed revealed the secret, it is true. I deserve to die. And I have no reason to live anymore.”

“No, Catra! Apologize! Save yourself!”

“No!” the catgirl repeats.

“You will die!”

“I despise life. The source of all my joy has dried up. All my hopes are gone, I only long to die.”

“To die? Ah, no, you must live!”, says Scorpia. “You must live for those who love you! I cannot experience this terrible agony. I stayed up all night in tears... Catra! I would do anything for you!”

“Scorpia...” says Catra, her voice suddenly full of tenderness. “Forgive me. I have fallen into disgrace and betrayal. And you worry about me? Poor Scorpia... I will die, but you will live. Be happy. And forget me!”

“No, Catra, no. Save yourself!”

“I cannot!”

“Don’t be stubborn! Do you really want to die, you fool?”

“I’m ready for it!”

“Silence!” Shadow Weaver shouts, interrupting their conversation. The sorceress steps forward and speaks directly to Catra. “No one can save you from your fate. You have proven what I have always said: that you are a pathetic and worthless creature. But I had no

idea that you were also a traitor. You gave the Horde's military secrets to the enemy, and you let the princess escape with that information. And because of that, the survivors of the Bright Moon Rebellion were able to elude our ambush and returned safely to their kingdom. Now revenge will be carried out: death will fall upon you!"

Catra remains silent for a moment, but then she starts laughing and turns to Shadow Weaver with a defiant look. "Do you think you scare me, witch? Death is the greatest good for me! My heart will rejoice when I meet my destiny... I no longer fear your wrath, only your mercy. It's true, I betrayed the Horde, but I have suffered a far worse betrayal. And it has taken away my desire to live!"

Ah, Wildcat!, thinks Scorpia. *Who can save you? I feel like I'm dying myself. I swear on my tears, I will know how to avenge you.*

"My Lord," says Shadow Weaver, addressing Hordak. "By your will, justice shall now be done."

"Force Captain Catra!" Lord Hordak shouts, finally looking at the prisoner. "Do you have absolutely nothing to say on your behalf? This is your last chance. Defend yourself."

Catra remains mute, her eyes raised proudly to stare at Hordak. Not a word is heard.

"She is silent!" says Shadow Weaver.

"Traitor!" shouts everyone present.

"Oh, have mercy!" cries Scorpia. "She is innocent! Mercy! Mercy!"

"Force Captain Catra!" repeats Lord Hordak. "You conspired with Princess Glimmer, the enemy of the Horde, on the eve of battle. Why did you do it? Defend yourself."

Once again, Catra remains mute.

“She is silent!”

“Traitor!”

“Have mercy!” cries Scorpia.

“Force Captain Catra!” Hordak shouts for the third time. “You have betrayed the Horde, your Lord, and your duties, after I had bestowed upon you the highest of honors. Why did you do it? Defend yourself.”

Catra remains mute.

“She is silent!”

“Traitor!”

“Mercy! Mercy!”

A few interminable moments pass. Then Lord Hordak speaks again.

“Your fate is decided,” he says. “You shall die a traitor’s death. In the ancient temple of the First Ones, deep in the Whispering Woods, you shall be entombed. The doors will be sealed. In there, without food or air, you shall die!”

Entombed alive... in that grave! Oh, Catra!, thinks Scorpia. *May they be cursed. Will their thirst for blood never be quenched? Only now do I realize the true and evil nature of the Horde. And to think that I have served them until now! My poor Wildcat!*

“Traitor! Traitor! Traitor!” the other captains continue to chant. Catra remains impassive.

“Take her to her cell,” Shadow Weaver orders. “And in the meantime, prepare a transport. She will soon be taken to her final resting place.”

Two guards approach the catgirl and lift her up. The chains that bound her to the floor are replaced by other cuffs. Catra is carried out of the hall as the Horde captains continue to shout, "Traitor! Death! Death!"

Wicked, bloodthirsty beasts!, Scorpia thinks. *But the last word is not yet spoken. I can still save her. And I swear I will!*

The cell is cold and bright, with an incessant hum in the background. Catra sits, her hands cuffed, waiting for the guards to return and finally take her to her tomb. And in the meantime, she lets her mind wander back to a certain blonde girl. To a pair of beautiful blue eyes. And to some words she never, not even in her wildest dreams, had hoped to hear.

I love you too! I love you so much!

Yes, Adora told her that. Obviously she was lying. It was a cruel deception to force her to reveal the location of the Horde armies, which routes were occupied and which were free. And she fell for it right away.

Of course it was a trap. How could Adora love her? Catra is not worthy of being loved. It was just a vain illusion.

And yet, that kiss... That tender, quick, fleeting kiss, so full of love and passion... was that also an illusion? It doesn't seem possible... And yet it is, there is no other explanation. The cruelest of deceptions. Catra still retains her taste, a last moment of happiness that the catgirl will take with her into death...

A sound outside the cell brings her back to this world.

"Catra! Catra, I found you!" calls Scorpia.

“Scorpia? How did you get in there?”

“Oh, boy. It was quite the heist,” replies the scorpion princess. “Very high-level, dangerous stuff. Now come on, I’m busting you out. We don’t have a lot of time before...”

“No, Scorpia. I already told you. I have no desire to live anymore. By killing me, they will do me a favor.”

“Enough of this nonsense. You must live, I told you! If not for me, at least for Adora!”

“Adora?” says Catra. And then she starts to laugh again. “Adora... Adora! To live for her? Ugh, you really don’t understand anything. It’s just the opposite. I want to die because of her.”

“Huh? What do you mean?”

“I love her, Scorpia! I love her! And she... she deceived me. She betrayed me.”

“But she loves you too, Wildcat!”

“Shut up! You don’t know what you’re talking about,” Catra growls.

“But it’s true! I know it for sure! She told me herself. What were her words? Let me remember... Ah, yes! *I love her so much, with an immense and secret love. I have never revealed it to her.* So she told me. Scout’s honor!”

“W-what?”

“I assure you, Wildcat. That girl is madly, desperately in love with you. There’s no doubt about it!”

“But... But then...” says Catra. Her head is spinning. A thousand thoughts form in her mind before going off in a thousand different directions.

“Catra, you must escape!” says Scorpia.

“Alas, it is too late!” says Catra. “Even if Adora loves me, my fate is already sealed. The guards will come for me soon. And you can’t save me. But maybe... maybe you can do something else for me. It is dangerous, but... Do you promise? Will you do it?”

“Of course I will! Ask me anything you want.”

“In my private room, behind the locker... you will find a secret hatch. And hidden behind is a sword. Take it with you, but don’t let anyone see it. And find a way to get it to Bright Moon. You have to get it back into Adora’s hands! It’s very important, Scorpia. Do you promise me?”

“I promise you, Wildcat!” Scorpia says with tears in her eyes.

“Thank you, Scorpia... You really care about me, don’t you?”

“Of course I care. You’re Catra. You’re our leader. You’re... you’re my friend. You’re everything to me.”

Catra pauses for a moment. Then, with a sweet glance, she looks intently at the scorpion princess. “Thank you... Thank you so much. Now I can die happy.”

“Wildcat!”

The footsteps of the guards echo in the corridor. The time has come. Catra’s destiny is about to be fulfilled. Scorpia retreats slowly, disappearing into the shadows. The catgirl closes her eyes, a serene smile now lighting her face.

The dungeon under the temple built by the First Ones is dark and dusty. The walls are infested with cobwebs. Mysterious

engravings, in an archaic language forgotten by all, cover the columns and all surfaces. A faint glow emanates from the same walls, perhaps fueled by some magical form of energy. *Magic,* Catra thinks. *Just what I needed. I will die surrounded by magic. I hope hunger and thirst will get me before I have to deal with some strange creature.*

The former Force Captain takes a few steps in one direction, but almost immediately changes her mind and sits down against a wall.

The fatal stone has closed above me. This is my tomb. I shall no longer see the light of day. And most of all... I will never see Adora again.

A soft noise comes from the corridor. Maybe an animal got trapped here with her? A mouse, perhaps? Catra hopes not, she doesn't have a good relationship with rats. The topic somehow makes her smile. She remembers a joke Adora often played on her, knowing exactly how she would react to her provocations.

Adora, my love, where are you now?, Catra thinks. *May you at least live happily. Fight and win your battles as She-Ra. And forget me and my horrid fate!*

That noise again. And this time it is getting closer. Catra looks up in the direction of the sound. And in the darkness, she can barely make out a human figure. Surprised, she stands up.

The figure comes closer and closer, until it is close enough to be recognized. "Oh gods! Adora!" the catgirl exclaims.

"Yes, Catra, it's me!" the blonde says.

"You... in this tomb!"

"In my heart, I sensed your fate. So I secretly entered this temple that was opened to receive you... And here, far from any human eye, I have chosen to die in your arms!"

“Adora! What have you done? You had to stay in Bright Moon! There, Scorpia would have found you... She would have brought you the sword. But instead...”

“Instead, I’m here with you, Catra, my love! I couldn’t live without you. I prefer to die with you!”

“To die... so pure, so beautiful!” cries Catra. “To die, for love of me! In the bloom of your youth, to give up your life! Heaven created you for love, yet I’m killing you for loving you! No, you shall not die! I have loved you too much, you are too beautiful to die!”

“My love, don’t cry,” Adora says, hugging and kissing her. “See? The angel of death is coming, with shining wings, to carry us to eternal happiness. The sky will open above us. There all sorrow ends, and there joy begins, the joy of immortal love.”

“The angel of death...?” asks Catra in tears.

“Yes, do you see? Their radiance lights up the room.”

“Adora... No, you dumb idiot!... That’s not an angel! That is...”

“...Glimmer!?” they both exclaim, as the pink-haired princess materializes in front of them, appearing in a cloud of sparks. And she’s not alone: with her is Scorpia! And they bring with them two precious weapons: Adora’s magic sword and Catra’s battle staff.

“There you are!” Glimmer says. “Sorry to interrupt. I know you were making out, taking advantage of being here alone, but we came to rescue you!”

“Hi, Wildcat!” Scorpia says, hugging her. “You’re safe now. Grab your weapon and let’s go!”

“S-Scorpia!” says Catra, confused and blushing profusely. “But what...? How did you manage to...?”

“I defected,” Scorpia answers with a broad smile. “I went to Bright Moon, and the princesses took me in! You know, the Horde always told me I was different, that I wouldn’t fit in with them at all, but they made me feel the opposite of not belonging, which I guess is... belonging? And I’m pretty sure they’ll do the same with you!”

“That’s right, Horde scum!” Glimmer adds. “The invitation to come with us still stands. Besides, Adora cannot fully function without you. So we need you if we are going to win this war!”

Catra and Adora look at each other, still blushing. Neither of them knows what to say.

Suddenly, a red light starts flashing in the hallway. “Unauthorized presence detected. Security protocol activated,” a mechanical voice announces. The walls begin to rise, fiery red eyes appearing behind them. Giant spiders begin to surround the four girls.

“Uh-oh,” Glimmer says. “We’re in trouble. I don’t think I have enough magic to teleport everyone away!”

“And I don’t have enough strength to move the stones that are trapping us,” Scorpia adds.

“What can we do? And what, by each and every god, are these things?” asks Catra.

“Don’t worry!” Adora reassures them. And after giving her girlfriend a complicit and loving smile, she grabs her sword, raises it high and recites:

“For the honor of Grayskull!”

End Notes

Thanks to SilverGM for reading and correcting some passages.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!